



World's tallest tower in China

China has revealed plans of building the world's tallest pair of towers which will be bright fuchsia in colour
<http://dgit.in/1rnpiv5>



Vine from the ISS

Astronauts aboard the ISS, having been posting amazing photos and this recent vine escalates it completely
<http://dgit.in/1sxmaui>

Bazaar

ASUS Sabertooth Z97 Mark 1

It's dressed like a knight amongst peasants

The Sabertooth series has long been known to stand different from the rest. The shielding across the board continues to be unique to the Sabertooth series. If you are seeing such a board for the first time, then a little information about the board's main feature is necessary. The Sabertooth boards are built to be rugged and durable. There is a plastic shield covering the front of the board which has slots for the peripherals and add-on card slots. Then you have two vents for small fans to be attached for cooling. Since the Z87 motherboard, the Sabertooth even has a metal backplate (approximately 1 mm thick) to reduce bending stress on the motherboard. And lastly, almost all external and internal ports have plastic inserts to seal them off.

The Z97 Sabertooth has two iterations, the Mark 1 and the Mark 2. The former is the more feature rich between the two motherboards. The main differences would be the lack of 2 SATA 6GB/s ports and a SATA Express port on the Mark 2. The Mark 1 has two gigabit ethernet ports while the Mark 2 only has the Intel Gigabit ethernet port. And lastly, the Mark 2 doesn't have the thermal armour, back plate and dust guards. If you wish to focus on the more functional aspects of the board then you'll go for the Mark 2 which is priced about ₹5,000 cheaper than the Mark 1.

Having so many features focusing on one aspect can result in features being sacrificed on other fronts or if there are no reduction in features then you can surely expect a humongous price increment. With the Sabertooth Z97 Mark 1 this becomes evident when you look at the memory frequency support, the manual mentions that modules rated up till 1866 MHz are supported but you can always overclock and get more. In this manner, the OVL lists 2666 MHz modules as the highest this board was tested with. Other features like LED debug code panel and the more popular M.2 port are missing. ASUS does make available an adaptor available (not included with the motherboard) which connects to the SATA Express port and provides for two M.2 cards to be set up in RAID 0 also there is the Hyper Express SSD enclosure which.

The board doesn't have any analog video output ports nor a PS/2 port. But there are plenty of USB 3.0 ports (4 on the rear and 4 via headers). Moreover, there is a Thunderbolt header as well which requires an add-on card to be inserted first.

The Thunderbolt card has been around for a while and more manufacturers have started including the header on their boards but with USB 3.0 being quite fast Thunderbolt hasn't really caught on.

The board is exceptionally well built given that the theme of the board is all about durability. The rear metal backplate other than reinforcing the board also acts as a heat sink for some of the transistors placed on the rear of the board. The dust covers which come with the Mark 1 are things that are cheap to produce yet aren't included with most motherboards. Some competitors have silicon covers for the rear I/O panel but internal connectors are generally left out. These internal inserts are especially helpful if you happen to live near the coast since corrosion is a huge problem in these areas. Moving on, it might occur to most enthusiasts that the plastic cover and the rear metal back plate might impede the installation of a custom cooler but the height of the plastic body around the CPU is about 35 mm tall and 26 mm without the shield. The rear backplate has a huge 100 mm x 118 mm cutout for those coolers with massive backplates.

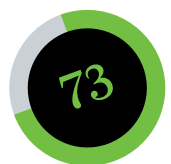
For the audio, the Sabertooth Z97 uses the Realtek ALC1150 which is a pretty good codec with great implementation. An isolated power supply for the audio section isn't something we haven't seen so far. What ASUS has done more is to isolate the left and right channels from each other by running the traces on different layers on the PCB.

While the board may not have an M.2 port and support for high frequency ram modules, is still stands out on its own because its USP is durability. And a few sacrifices on the features front have been more than compensated. However, when compared to what the competitors have to offer, the Mark 2 might turn out to be more popular among the general masses because of its competitive price tag.

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Price
₹19,100



Features 66
Build 80

Specifications

Chipset: Intel Z97; **Memory support:** 4x1866 MHz upto 32GB; **LAN:** Intel I218V and Realtek 8111GR Gigabit Ethernet; **Audio:** ALC1150 7.1; **SATA:** 8x SATA III; **Expansion:** 3x PCIe X16(x16+x8+x4); **Dimensions (LxWxD):** 305 mm x 244 mm; **Warranty:** 5 years

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